While U.S. policymakers and media have often portrayed the Cubans as acting as proxies for the USSR, most serious scholars tell a different story. “Fidel Castro is nobody’s puppet,” Jorge Domínguez concluded in 1989. “Cuba led the USSR in fashioning policies toward Central America, inducing the Soviets to behave in ways they might otherwise not have behaved … Cuba has served as a broker and advocate for other governments, especially Grenada’s, in their relations with the Soviet Union.”[30] Likewise Piero Gleijeses’s definitive accounts of Cuba’s involvement in Africa conclude that it was the Cubans who dragged an unwilling USSR into support for the Africans.

“The aid Cuba gave Algeria in 1961–2 had nothing to do with the East–West conflict,” stated Gleijeses flatly. “Its roots predated Castro’s victory in 1959 and lay in the Cubans’ widespread identification with the struggle of the Algerian people.” Independent Algeria’s new President, Ahmed Ben Bella, visited Cuba soon after taking office in 1962. “The two youngest revolutions of the world met, compared their problems and together envisioned the future,” Ben Bella explained.[31]

Moscow, seeking detente with the United States in the 1970s, had little enthusiasm for African entanglements. As the CIA concluded in 1976, “Cuba is not involved in Africa solely or even primarily because of its relationship with the Soviet Union. Rather, Havana’s African policy reflects its activist revolutionary ethos and its determination to expand its own political influence in the Third World at the expense of the West (read U.S.).”[32]

Civilian Aid Missions

Although Cuba’s military involvement has received more attention, another side of Cuban involvement in Africa and Latin America has been the flood of Cuban aid workers, teachers, and doctors, around the world. Cuba, political scientist Julie Feinsilver notes, has created the largest civilian aid program in the world – not only in comparison to its size and resources, but even in absolute numbers. From 1963, when the first 56 Cuban health workers traveled to work in Algeria, through 1991,